

Figure 9: Fuzzy Select and Colour to Alpha

job much snappier and more efficient while creating headers, buttons and logos. The new polygon selection tool is the real icing on the cake.

Colour selection and 'colour to alpha'

If you are not well versed with the Path Tool and Free Selection, and you want to remove the background from an image, then these two colour tools come in handy. Both of them work pretty differently.

With the colour select tool, you first select the tool from the tool bar and then click the colour you want to select/remove, and press **Delete**. That will remove the selected colour from the background. But it will leave some traces on the border of the image/colour. Later on, you can use the blur effect on the borders to smoothen it.

'Colour to alpha' takes the same process to the next level. It makes it even easier for you to remove the background. Select the colour you want to remove from the 'wand' tool and navigate to **Colour→Colour to alpha** and apply the effect.

Custom brush

Have you ever wondered how those beautiful brushes are made? You probably think that one must be adept with vector graphics to create these brushes. Well, you are wrong! Although most of the scalable brushes are created using vector graphics, creating brushes in GIMP is child's play. Yes, simply open an image, select it and copy it, and bingo! You have just created a new brush. This new brush will appear in the brush window and you can save it by clicking on the **Save** button.

The GIMP is certainly one of the best image editors available out there, and version 2.6 is no exception. Though a majority of the changes lie in the core, some of the user-level features make it a pretty nifty update. The inclusion of GEGL and CMYK support has certainly opened new doors for this venerable FOSS image editing application.

Version 2.6 tries to leverage the gap between paid alternatives and freely available tools. But with incomplete

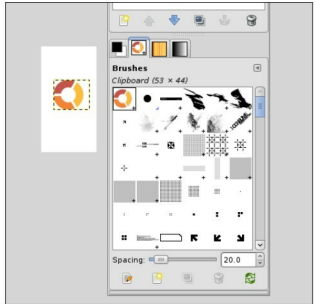


Figure 10: Creating a new brush

integration and UI improvements it still has a long way to go.

Looking forward, it seems that version 2.8 will be a killer release. Developers have revealed some plans for the next stable version: on-canvas text editing, merger of finished projects from the Google Summer of Code, a revamped user interface and better GEGL integration.

Till then, let's wait. But, just in case you haven't tried GIMP

out, then 2.6 is the release for you. As for the missing features... well, as they say, "Rome was not built in a day!" The GIMP has already gained some much-needed momentum, and with GEGL and CMYK on board, it seems it's destined to gain a lot of respect among the pros. **END**

The GIMP 2.6.3



Pros:

Fast, uses low resources, great alternative to Photoshop, FOSS, GEGL, lots of plug-ins and tools available.

Cons:

Complex user interface for newbies, lacks few advance image editing features, incomplete GEGL integration.

Platform: Universal

Price: Free (as in beer)

Website: www.gimp.org



Notes and references

- Home Page: www.gimp.org
- Release Notes: gimp.org/release-notes/gimp-2.6.html
- Gimp Wiki: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/GIMP
- GIMP UI: gimp-brainstorm.blogspot.com
- CMYK: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/CMYK

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